

CHENNAI • Thursday, April 30, 2026

metroPLUS

THE HINDU

Recounting what the 300-year-old Armenian Church's belfry means in today's times **P3**

VIGNESH RAJA ON DIRECTING DHANUSH IN KARA **P4**



Dhee talks about her new Tamil single 'Vari Vari', and how longing shapes her music

Pop goes the soul

The right notes
Dhee. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

S Poorvaja
poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

In 'Vari Vari', a red Beetle car winds its way down a scenic coastal road. In it, Australian-Tamil singer Dhee, bursts into song. It is a homecoming that still feels unsettled as she embarks on a journey to find a version of herself that feels lost.

Dhee harkens back to sitting down with music composer Santhosh Narayanan and lyricist Vivek when they worked on this new single. 'Vari Vari' is Dhee's second single in Tamil after 'Enjoy Enjaami' in 2021, which she sang with rapper Arivu.

"When Vivek *anna* and I were discussing emotions, we landed on melancholy. It is the key word in this song... it feels like you are talking to a mirror, a longing for an inner child you seem to have left behind and finding that by the end of the song," she says.

The song, both upbeat and soulful, is a pop track that is rooted in Tamil folk with lyrics by Vivek. Dhee has been credited as a producer (along with Santhosh) and as songwriter (with Santhosh and Vivek).

At Gatz in the integrated resort City Of Dreams in Colombo, Santhosh, Vivek and Dhee unveiled the song and engaged in a discussion about how the single came to be. "I am thrilled to be here and was so happy for my friends and family who flew in to be with me for the launch," Dhee says.

Music as an outlet

Dhee's biggest indie hit remains her first Tamil single, 'Enjoy Enjaami' — a song that has also been mired in controversy over the sharing of credits and royalties between Arivu and Santhosh. Has all of this altered the way the song has shaped her life and journey, or has it come to mean something different over time?

"I think the song will always be super special for me, and the other creators because it is all about life, and bringing people together. I still love performing the

song, and love seeing people, especially children coming up to me and calling me 'cuckoo cuckoo akka'," she says. The philosophy of the song, Dhee says, is something she continues to apply to her life. "It pretty much always brings people together," she says.

Her repertoire includes frequent collaborations with Santhosh Narayanan, as well as songs for AR Rahman, GV Prakash Kumar and Anirudh Ravichander.

For Dhee, working with Santhosh is something she says feels like an extension of herself. "Singing for Santhosh appa...it is like the only thing I have ever known because I started off singing with him in the movies. There is an extra level of comfort, and he also does not try to babysit my feelings," she says.

While she says she has, and continues to learn from every musician she has been around, we ask her who features on her work wishlist. "Sai (Abhyankkar) and I have been wanting to work together for a while. I have seen him since he was a kid, and it will be fun when we do collaborate," she says.

While she shares that her biggest dream is to be an artist who puts out full-fledged albums, Dhee adds that a large part of this vision is rooted in bringing more of "our" sound into the mainstream. "Folk music, or *makkal isai* in particular... my biggest dream is to see this in the mainstream pop space," she says.

For now, she hopes to travel with her music, and even perform in Chennai soon.

"I have been travelling between Sri Lanka, Australia and Los Angeles for the last two years and living this nomadic life. I do not have a sense of where home is, and I feel like a lot of this has triggered my recent writing. This longing reflects in my singing too," she says.

She goes on to speak about how much she misses home — Kolapakkam in Chennai — along with the neighbourhood dogs. "Life dictates what you create, and for me, I feel this need to get my feelings out there... sort of like writing in a diary."

AKHILA EASWARAN



Pick up percussion

At Jus Drums, there is a variety of percussion to choose from at their 24th annual summer camp; the drums, konakkol or the art of vocal percussion which has its origins in South India, cajón which is a box-shaped instrument from Peru played by slapping its hide, and the djembe, a goblet-shaped drum played commonly in West Africa.

"Rhythm is something that comes naturally to everyone, and I think it is a great outlet for children. Through summer, children signing up for the camp can choose to learn an instrument of their choice. I prefer that the participants are beginners," says S Muralikrishnan, popularly known as Drums Murali. The annual concert of the school of percussion follows the camp, where students get to take the stage and showcase their summer rhythms.

@Jus Drums, Alwarpet. For ages five and upwards. For details and registrations, contact 9840046827.



From learning kalari to delving into how nation building and the Constitution works, Chennai has a host of interesting activities in store for children this summer. We bring you some that promise to be fun, creatively challenging and most importantly, indoors

Camp out, this summer

S Poorvaja
poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in



Dance like a K-Pop star

K-Pop music video more often than not, leaves you wondering if you will ever bust out a move the way your favourite idols do. At their K-Pop dance summer camp this year, members of city-based K-pop dance group LDC, Rhea Rajkumar, Aradhana Pallavi, and Sruthi S say they aim to get participants comfortable with K-pop choreography.

"We have camps running through May, June and July, and will teach the choreo to nine different K-Pop songs. At the end of the camp, the participants will participate in a showcase," Sruthi says. Aradhana explains that the focus will be on style and technique for different songs. "K-Pop dance follows a mix of different styles, so it will be interesting to explore this," she adds.

@Feet2Feet Dance Studio, Anna Nagar East from May 9 onwards. For more details, visit @ldc_official_ on Instagram

Explore nation building

With the aim of nurturing thoughtful leaders, The Equals Project has an immersive five-day programme for the summer, which introduces nation building and the Indian Constitution to young students.

"The participants delve into ideas within the Constitution, its relevance in 2026, how it is different from other laws of the land, and concepts related to public policy. We ground this programme in Indian history, look at how decisions were made and look at it through a social, moral and political lens. The idea is to build critical thinking, awareness and leadership among our young participants," says Shruthi Viswanathan, founder. "One key question the course tries to address is how one can work with people they do not necessarily agree with, and how they can build coalitions with them and better understand their point of view," she adds.

With a focus on experiential learning, the programme also includes a simulation component where the participants in this cohort draft a constitution based on the motivations and interests of characters or identities assigned to them.

@The Learning Community at Quest, Rukmani Road extension, Kalakshetra Colony, Besant Nagar. From May 18 to 22. For classes VIII-XII. For registrations, log onto theequalsproject.in/summer-programme-2026/

Learn kalari

One of the world's oldest martial arts, kalaripayattu, will be made accessible to children at the Viram Juniors summer camp. "Children love running around and expending energy in the most unique ways possible, so this is a great chance for them to delve into kalari. We incorporate a lot of animal-based movement, crawling, jumping and rolling which they immensely enjoy," says Shweta Bhargavi, a kalari practitioner, who will lead the camp along with Akshay.

In addition to this, Shweta says they will be taught simple ways of how to defend themselves, teach them vocal commands which makes them feel like a part of a big army and give them insight into how ancient warriors used to practise. "They can experience a very disciplined, yet fun environment where they also learn how to focus on themselves over hurting another person. We aim to channel their energy and bring out the best in them," she adds.

@ Edit Hybrid Fitness, Kilpauk, from May 11 to 16 for ages seven to 16. For registrations, contact 7540033057.



Tell a story through comics

Have stories that you want to put on paper? Children's books illustrator Satwik Gade will teach you how to master the art of storytelling through comic strips, at a summer art workshop organised by Tulika Publishers. "There are no prior drawing skills required and the idea is to focus more on the storytelling aspects. There are several

hugely successful comics simply based on stick figures. Comic drawing by nature is supposed to be simple," says Satwik. His workshop will take participants through studying the anatomy of a comic, how to write for one and will conclude with them trying their hand at creating a zine. "There is no one right way of making a comic and I want the participants to be able to express themselves in their own way," he adds.

@Tulika Bookstore, 305, Manickam Avenue, Alwarpet from May 8 to 12. For ages 10 to 14. Contact reachus@tulikabooks.com or 9791192070 for registrations.

A Shajahan and his wife Parveen Banu who own a 40-acre farm in Salem near Adimalaipatty village, Karadi Kadu; freshly-harvested alphonso mangoes.



Banu, who owns the farm. The birds partake of the season's best even before harvest begins. There are trees heaving with perfectly round alphonso mangoes that are slightly curved at the bottom end; the elongated kilimooku variety with a dusting of pink on their deep green skin; and bulbous thick-skinned malgova mangoes hanging in clumps. Salem's mangoes are popular across Tamil Nadu and Karnataka, especially Bengaluru that is 185 kilometres away. In April and May, farmers from the region drive down to the city with

Organic alphonso is priced at ₹100 a kilogram, ₹180 for imam pasandh, ₹140 for Salem bangalura, and ₹150 for malgova. Call 6379422164 for details.

What is brewing
Students at
The Brew
School in
Kochi.
SPECIAL
ARRANGEMENT

The Brew School is located at 1st Floor, 70, Central Street, Kilpauk Garden Colony, Kilpauk. To enroll, log on thebrewschool.in.

Drinks start at ₹1,200, and a meal for two costs ₹2,000.

CM
YK

Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

Do bells clang, chime, or ring? On Armenian Genocide Remembrance Day on April 24, they seemed to toll, ringing across the streets of George Town.

There is nothing more definitive about this area than a flurry of black lawyer gowns, derelict century-old buildings, and mayhem on the streets. The demeanour of this neighbourhood, just North of Fort St George, insists that in order to be alive, one must first sweat. Amidst the chaos though, is an oasis of iridescent white calm. The 300-year-old church dedicated to Saint Mary – located on Armenian Street opposite the High Court of Madras, acts as an insulator, cutting off honks, chatter and the harsh sun.

Upon entering this chamber of quiet I am struck by the view of a stellar belfry (pronounced bel-free and not fry, as I learnt yesterday). It is the church complex's only real medium of sound. When we climb to the top and inspect the bells up close, I am unsure about what to expect, particularly because of how old they look.

Jude Johnson, the caretaker of the Armenian church, stands at the precipice of the structure, holding on to six thick ropes, each connected to its six bells, weighing around 150 kilograms each. "Shall I ring it?" he asks. Several deep, heavy clangs rush through the air. "It is a special day, it is okay to ring it," he reconciles with himself.

"It is so calming, isn't it?" asks Ashkhen Khachatryan, an Armenian who researches the community's connection to Chennai.

The 300-year-old bell tower of the Armenian Church of St Mary is one of the most remarkable symbols of Armenian heritage in Chennai, says Ashkhen. "It houses six historic bells, each connected to the story of the Armenian community in old Madras," she adds.

When early Armenians arrived in Chennai as merchants and traders in the mid 1600s, they began realising the need for a formal space of prayer. The church on the eponymous street



The sound of home

Three hundred years have gone by, but the Armenian church's six sonorous bells continue to spread calm, and remind some others of a home far and beyond

was built in 1712 as a small wooden chapel, and later reconstructed in 1772. The six bells in the belfry were used to call the congregation to attend services and gatherings. "At that time, Madras had a larger Armenian population, so the bells

played an important community role," she says.

Ashkhen says that the first and oldest bell, dating to 1754, became even more distinctive when its lettering was reworked in 1808 by a local Madras foundry named Arulapan. The name Arulapan

For whom the bell tolls (Left) The six bells at the belfry of Chennai's Armenian Church are rung on special occasions ; (below) a view of the belfry from outside. B JOTHI RAMALINGAM



can still be seen on the bell, written in Tamil script. It was gifted in memory of 'Mnatsakan', a then-resident by his father Ghukas. "It makes the bell especially significant, as it reflects a rare meeting of Armenian heritage and Tamil craftsmanship. It shows how the Armenian community in Madras was closely connected with local artisans who helped preserve and maintain their sacred objects," she says.

All but two bells lie suspended from thick Burma teak beams that seems to have stood the time. "They are impossibly strong and require little maintenance. Just regular cleaning," Jude says.

Another one of these bells dates to 1778. "There are two others from the 1790s which were donated in memory of Eleazar Shameer, a young member of the prominent Shameer family who died at just 19. The final two bells are from 1837 and were cast in London by Thomas Mears, one of the leading bell founders of the time. Their donor names are not mentioned, but they were likely gifted by wealthy Armenian benefactors of Madras," Ashkhen says.

There is a reason why the

belfry continues to charm visitors till date. The bells are rung every Sunday morning by the caretaker and whenever Armenians visit the church. Ashkhen says that her son loves pulling the rope and hearing the peals when they visit.

They are also rung on Armenian Christmas (celebrated in January), Easter, Armenian Genocide Remembrance Day, Republic Day, and other meaningful community events. "It serves as a living symbol of the Armenian presence in Chennai. Everytime I am there, I think of the time from centuries ago when people from my country once sat in the same chairs listening to this service," Ashken says.

She adds that for Armenians who visit today, the bells are deeply emotional. Their sound creates a connection between past and present. "Many visitors say they have never heard bells with such a beautiful and powerful tone as the bells of the Armenian Church in Madras. When they ring, it is more than sound – it is memory, identity, and belonging," she says. "I am several thousand kilometres away from home but during those moments, I am transported."

STEPOUT



Learn through play

At a children's theatre workshop led by theatre practitioners Aparna Gopinath and Santha Kumar, participants will explore movement, storytelling and play. With specially designed activities rooted in theatre and clowning traditions, the workshop offers an opportunity for children to grow through art. @Shree Music Academy, Choolaimedu. May 4 to 14, 9am to noon. Fee is ₹8,000. Call 9080267665.



Be the riddler

X Quiz It, a quizzing organisation, is offering an online summer quiz camp for students in two groups, classes V to VII and classes VIII to XI. The five-day camp includes sessions with quizmasters, live interactions and daily sessions. All participants will receive certificates. From May 18 to 22 and fees cost ₹2,500. Log on to xquizit.org.



Art of floating ink

Learn suminagashi, the Japanese art of floating ink through this workshop which

will offer an introduction to the traditional art of ink marbling, where patterns created on water are transferred onto paper. The hands-on session covers basic techniques of the meditative art form, with participants creating their own marbled works. @Wangs Kitchen, Alwarpet, daily until May 3. 5.30pm to 6.30pm, fee is ₹799 per person. Tickets at bookmyshow



Kashmir in frames

Kashmir: Visual Poetry brings together 39 photographs by Chennai-based physician and photographer Dr. Srinivasan Periyathiruvadi, capturing the many moods of Kashmir across seasons and lived moments. Shot over seven years and multiple journeys into the valley, including its quieter, more remote corners, the images move between sweeping landscapes, wildlife encounters, and fragments of everyday life.

"The photographs document the landscape through autumn, winter, spring and everyday human activity in the valley," says Dr. Srinivasan. "Through these photographs, I hope to encourage more people to visit Kashmir."

The exhibition unfolds in a gentle rhythm, with sections dedicated to autumn's burnished hues, the stark poetry of winter, the renewal of spring, and scenes of daily life that anchor the valley beyond its postcard beauty. Printed as large-format works on archival photo paper, the images invite viewers to linger — to see not just a place, but a passage of time.

The show will be inaugurated by Mahmood Ahmad Shah, KAS, a senior bureaucrat whose long engagement with the region extends beyond administration. A trekker, photographer, and author, Mahmood Ahmad has spent over two decades exploring more than 100 lakes across Jammu and Kashmir, a pursuit that culminated in his book, *Valleys of Jammu & Kashmir*. Dr. Srinivasan notes that this body of work has been a source of inspiration.

"It is my mission to promote Kashmir as a tourist destination, where there is much to see and enjoy," says Dr. Srinivasan. On view at Lalit Kala Akademi, Greams Road, from May 2 to 7, 11am to 7pm. Entry is free.

CREAMCentre
VEGETARIAN LEGEND SINCE 1998
Veg Fine Dining Restaurant

ALPHONSO MANGO SPECIAL

Indulge in the richness of seasonal mango specials.
A perfect blend of flavour and summer joy.

For Banquets & Outdoor Catering ☎ 98843 96651 / 98843 59759

RA Puram 044 4281 5777 | Nungambakkam 044 4356 1777 | Anna nagar 044 4353 7077 | Adyar 044 4630 4777

SATHYAM | ESCAPE | INOX CITY CENTRE | PVR AMPA MALL | EGA | WOODLANDS | PVR PALAZZO | PVR VE MALL
PVR LUXE VELACHERY | PVR GRAND VELACHERY | PVR PALLABRAM | CINEPOLIS OM | INOX MARINA MALL | PVR ESR
PVR KEROHUB | PVR REDHILLS | INOX NATIONAL | AGS TRAGAR, MADURAVOYAL, OM, VILVAKKAM | PVR GRAND GALADA
MALL THRISSUR | S2 PERAMBUR | S2 THEYAGARAYA | KASI JAFFERKHAMPT | MATAJAAL ECR | ROHINI KOYAMBEDU | MIRAJ
PERUMBAKKAM | MOVIE MAX PR MALL WALTAX ROAD | RAKKI & MURUGAN AMBATUR | RADHA REDHILLS | MANI MINJUR
SIVASAKTHI PADI | VETRIVEL NANGANALLUR | MARVEL MOVIE MAX THIRUVALLUR | GANGA KOLATHUR | VIDYA TAMBARAM
VELS CHENNAI AMBAKKAM | VIGNESHWARA PODDUMALAI | VIJAY PARK HULSBARKKAM | RAKKI CINEMAS KILAMBARKAM
SEVEN SCREEN CINEMAS KILAMBARKAM | MVR SUDUVANCHERRY | SANTHALINGAM ORAGADAM | BABU KANCHIPURAM

RELEASING TOMORROW PATRIOT

RAJESH KUMAR | ANITA JOSEPH | ANIL KUMAR
CH. SATEEN, SUDASANA GURU, MANOJ
SODHAN, SATHYAN

RAJESH KUMAR | ANITA JOSEPH | ANIL KUMAR
CH. SATEEN, SUDASANA GURU, MANOJ
SODHAN, SATHYAN

THE DIVINE DAY

With Guru Maa Shubha Didi

1st MAY
FRIDAY

4:15 PM
- 7 PM

SIR MUTHA VENKATASUBBA
RAO CONCERT HALL CHETPET
(LADY ANDAL SCHOOL
CAMPUS)

The path to Divinity goes through Gates of Wisdom!

Blissful Discourse, Transformative Meditation, Soulful Bhajans,
Grand Visual Experience with a Message, And Much More....

2026

Entry by Pass Only

Scan to get your entry
ticket to Divinity

Language -
Hindi & English

@shubhadidi +91 95001 88555 / +91 81482 50655



Writer-director
Vignesh Raja on
managing star-led
expectations with
Dhanush-starrer *Kara*,
releasing today

A shot at glory

Bhuvanesh Chandar
bhuvanesh.chandar@thehindu.co.in

There's a method to the madness in how writer-director Vignesh Raja speaks about his writing and filmmaking process. Even the frames in his debut film, 2023's *Por Thozhil*, hinted at a man obsessed with precision and simplicity. He clarifies that this isn't his way of coping with the chaos of filmmaking. "I like to design my films. There is a logical and psychological reasoning behind every scene. A director gets to decide what needs to be in or out of the frame, which is a huge responsibility. I make it a point to be very careful when it comes to designing the shots and ensuring the audience's attention isn't diverted," says Vignesh, whose sophomore film, the Dhanush-starrer *Kara*, is set to release in theatres on April 30.

When we meet him, Vignesh seems visibly exhausted after a round of promotions and overseeing the sound mixing. "With *Por Thozhil*, no one expected much out of the film; *Kara* is bigger, and we are opening to a wider audience, so obviously the pressure is there," he says, adding that working till the last minute

helps as it keeps him occupied. Vignesh understands the visibility that a star like Dhanush brings to a project. "Films like *Por Thozhil* and *Kara* rely strongly on word of mouth because we are not giving you exactly what the film is. But a star like Dhanush brings in a base over which that can build. It is a cushion, but it also comes with its own expectations."

Kara germinated from a news article Vignesh chanced upon, about an incident in northern India. "It was a story of crime, but I had found it to be quite absurd, so I made a note of it. In my head, I thought this could be like *Soodhu Kavvum*, and so that was there. And then, a few months later, I read another article on similar

themes. That story was set somewhere close to Vellore. That was a very emotional, hard-hitting piece." *Kara* was then born out of combining these two ideas.

Vignesh and his writing partner, Alfred Prakash, who also co-authored *Por Thozhil*, worked on the screenplay of *Kara* for over eight months. Vignesh says working as a duo chiefly helps eliminate bad ideas. "If I come up with an idea, Alfred will play the devil's advocate and critically attack the idea – not from a place of ego, but with the intention of making the script better." Only when both of them are convinced does an idea enter the draft. "Writing is a very lonely process, so it helps to have a like-minded writing partner."

What also piques one's interest is how, after writing a police story in *Por Thozhil*, Vignesh and Alfred seem to have gotten the high of seeing things from the other extreme. Dhanush plays a robber in *Kara*. Vignesh admits there aren't any attempts to justify a robbery. "So we knew that he's going to start from a dark and morally flawed space." But the writers were aware that an actor like Dhanush, who has dabbled in shades of grey several times, would be game for it. "He's one of those few stars who's not very hung up on his image. He's always looking to serve the story, and so we didn't put any effort into

whitewashing the character."

Kara also stars Mamitha Baiju, KS Ravikumar, Karunaas, Jayaram, Suraj Venjaramoodu, Prithvi Pandiarajan and MS Baskar, among others. A thorough pre-production helps Vignesh spend much of his time on the sets with his actors. "Getting good performances starts with casting, and once they are in, we create a certain look that excites not only the audiences but also the actor." The director goes to the extent of giving costumes in advance and even ensuring the props are authentic. "Let's say a police officer has to open and see the case files, and he's talking to another person. Even if the camera doesn't show it, I'll make sure I give him the actual case files with actual photographs. So these subconsciously trick the actor into thinking it is actually happening."

After doing a film with Dhanush, you might expect a newcomer director to scale up and aim for a film with the likes of Rajinikanth and Ajith; that has almost become the norm. Not Vignesh Raja. "It all depends on the story. See, when I decide to make a film, it takes more than two years of my life. So that needs to mean something for me. The idea of seeing the story on screen need to be exciting. If that happens to be in a star film, then so be it. If it's the other way around, so be it."

Just days away from the release of the film, Vignesh only hopes that audiences don't walk in expecting a film just like *Por Thozhil* in terms of genre or story. "There are no deviations, distractions, and it's a tight screenplay. So, in spirit, it's the same, but in terms of setting or story or plot, it's a very different film."



SHIVARAJ S.



Dhanush is one of those few stars who's not very hung up on his image. He's always looking to serve the story

VIGNESH RAJA
Writer-director

Shreyas Pande
shreyas.pande@thehindu.co.in

To celebrate a couple's wedding anniversary, a bunch of friends get together at an old bungalow, and one amongst them gets murdered in the dead of the night. As any other murder-mystery, everyone is a suspect. But this not any murder-mystery. Directed by Rajat Kapoor, known for his off-beat storytelling of the oddly specific, *Everybody Loves Sohrab Handa* unfolds more like an immersive talkie than a stylistic genre piece. Named ironically after the aggressive murder victim, Sohrab Handa (Vinay Pathak), the film is a psychological study of a bully that he is. However, Handa is riddled with complexities, as the film also gives space for a softer side to him. "For me, people are not black and white. Everyone is a little grey. Nobody is just one thing. I tried to find a shaded human being in all this," says the actor-filmmaker.

Sohrab Handa is played with assurance by Vinay Pathak, a long-time friend and collaborator of Kapoor, having worked with him in films and plays. Pathak says that he didn't have to struggle much to embody Handa. "Rajat kept the character so cerebral and straight-forward that I didn't have to bring my own imagination to understand his mind. You know what kind of a person he is just by



Where the clues lead

Rajat Kapoor, Vinay Pathak and Ranvir Shorey discuss their recently-released murder-mystery *Everybody Loves Sohrab Handa*

reading his lines," says Pathak.

The film relies on dialogue to create a sense of tension between the characters, as all of them speak over each other, lending a distinct sense of theatricality to the happenings.

"It feels like a play as the story is set in one location and takes place in real-time. Our attempt while making it was to move away from the theatricality and find something cinematic in that. It is reflected in the camera choices and editing," Kapoor says.

Kapoor credits the actors for

Indie innings

(Left) Rajat Kapoor; and stills from *Everybody Loves Sohrab Handa*. ZEE5



being cooperative in the conversation scenes. "We had to do rehearsals of over two-three hours just to understand how actors will be moving in a shot. This is also one of the few films where all actors were together for all of the shooting time of 30 days," says the filmmaker.

Actor Ranvir Shorey, who plays the role of a professor, says that there were joint readings which helped in bringing out the dynamics of the conversations. "Rajat has become a master of capturing chaos. He manages to get something bigger out of things that may seem small. It is also not easy handling 15

'Song writing is therapy'

What independent musician Kabir Vasuki hopes to do with his Frangipani Tour 2026

Akila Kannadasan
akila.k@thehindu.co.in

Trigger warning: This article contains material related to suicide and mental illness. Discretion is advised.

The energy is electrifying inside the small space at Coimbatore's Medai — The Stage. Kabir Vasuki's Frangipani Tour 2026 is running to packed houses and the intimate crowd headbangs and grooves as the independent musician presents his popular compositions such as 'Poi', 'Mugamoodi', and 'Muthal Dum'. But when the lights dim and Kabir strums his guitar on the centrestage and goes, "En friend-u peru Nila..." there is silence.

Over the next few minutes, the 230-odd people in the audience sing along, swaying gently to the rhythm of 'Frangipani', Kabir's ode to a friend called Nila who died by suicide. The song was first released in 2025 as part of the six-track EP 'Raw Tapes 01', with its official music video being released last month. It has gone viral on YouTube ever since, becoming a medium of healing and dealing with grief and loss.

What did Nila mean to Kabir? "Nila was one of the few people who believed in my potential even before I was confident," he says: "She saw my spark and believed it would be a wildfire. Not just for me but for so many people around her. She had an instinct for nurturing people's dreams and giving them the doses of validation needed to help boost their own confidence in themselves. It was just who she was."

He recalls how in the early years of his career, she would show up at each of his performances, introducing his music to everyone she met.

In the Frangipani Tour 2026, that has so far been to Chennai, Bengaluru, and Coimbatore, Kabir shares 'fragments of memory' right from his Orkut years, moving on to the first time he met Nila, and their interactions over the years. Much of his music is from his life experiences that reveal the inner workings of his mind. "I write songs as a form of therapy, almost," he says.

"I don't mind revealing the inner workings of my mind because I'm sure the pathologies they expose are shared by so many more and there's a solace in knowing that the emotions and thoughts we carry with so much shame or guilt are rather common. I think there's a certain calming feeling that comes from knowing we're not alone or as different as we thought."

His band for the Frangipani tour consists of Big Sam on rhythm guitars and backing vocals, Renin Raphael on lead guitars, Judin Finny on bass and Samuel Moses on drums. They are next travelling to Malaysia with it and Kabir says that they will be taking it to more cities in the coming months.

Performing 'Frangipani' over and over again, says Kabir, takes a toll on him. He says, "Some days on stage I have to really hold back. I don't listen to or sing the song other than at the shows. I don't know how long I can do this song live as well, I think at some point I'll stop performing it live."



Emotion in verse
Kabir Vasuki in 'Frangipani'.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

people behind the camera and 15 in front of it."

Shorey, Pathak and Kapoor go back a long way. The three have been friends before they started working together in plays since 1999. Shorey met Pathak in 1997 and the two have seen each other grow since then. "We have worked together in television, films, theatre, advertising and also events. I don't think there's any medium left in the arts where we haven't worked together," Shorey smiles.

Shorey also feels that knowing your collaborators adds a sense of comfort while working. He explains, "It is like doing something you love with somebody you love. When you work more together and get to know each other better, you are able to do better work."

A glimpse of that easygoing dynamic is perhaps reflected in the authenticity with which each performance comes alive on-screen. *Everybody Loves Sohrab Handa* thrives on what remains of a relationship, whether it is between friends, a couple or a turbulent father-son bond. With all its merits and distinct aesthetic sense, the film was stuck for over three years after being screened at the MAMI Mumbai Film Festival in 2023. "That's how it is for independent films. Marketing them is tougher than making them."

Everybody Loves Sohrab Handa is currently streaming on ZEE5